SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #33 · TRUTH

“If a teaching makes me feel good, it must be from God.”

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Where it often comes from

Popular preaching that focuses mainly on comfort, success, and self-improvement. Past hurt from harsh teaching, which makes any challenge feel unsafe. Wanting God’s Word to always encourage and never correct. Social media and books that sound spiritual but are mostly positive thinking. Confusing emotional uplift with spiritual truth.

What Scripture teaches

God’s Word does bring comfort, hope, and joy. But Scripture also warns that people will gather teachers who say what their itching ears want to hear. God’s Word is living and active and sometimes cuts deeply, correcting us for our good. A friend’s honest wounds can be more faithful than an enemy’s kisses. The test of a teaching is whether it is true to Scripture, not whether it makes us feel good.

> *“For the time will come when men will not tolerate sound doctrine, but with itching ears they will gather around themselves teachers to suit their own desires. So they will turn their ears away from the truth and turn aside to myths”* **(2 Timothy 4:3–4)**.

Also see

> “For the word of God is living and active. Sharper than any double-edged sword, it pierces even to dividing soul and spirit, joints and marrow. It judges the thoughts and intentions of the heart” **(Hebrews 4:12)**.

> “All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for instruction, for conviction, for correction, and for training in righteousness, so that the man of God may be complete, fully equipped for every good work” **(2 Timothy 3:16–17)**.

> “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ” **(Galatians 1:10)**.

> “The wounds of a friend are faithful, but the kisses of an enemy are deceitful” **(Proverbs 27:6)**.

Common self-statements

- That sermon felt great, so it must be true.
- God would never say anything that makes me uncomfortable.
- If a teaching challenges me, it must be wrong.
- Real Christianity always makes you feel good.
- I only listen to teachers who encourage me.
- Correction is from the enemy.

Common logical errors

- **Emotional reasoning:** Judging a teaching by how it feels rather than by Scripture.
- **Selective attention:** Accepting comforting verses and avoiding challenging ones.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing truth must be either all comfort or all harshness.
- **Confirmation bias:** Seeking out only teachers who confirm what you want.

Challenging questions

- What does 2 Timothy 4:3–4 say about teachers who suit our desires?
- Does God's Word ever correct or challenge me?
- Is this teaching true to all of Scripture, or just to the parts I like?
- Have I ever needed a hard truth that didn't feel good at first?
- Am I avoiding a message because it's wrong, or because it's uncomfortable?
- What does Hebrews 4:12 say God's Word does?
- Can truth be loving and still be hard to hear?

Truth summary

> A teaching is not from God just because it makes me feel good. God's Word brings comfort, but it also corrects and challenges me for my good. I can test every teaching by Scripture, receive both encouragement and correction, and trust that God's truth is always loving, even when it is hard.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Truth
- Scripture/Word
- Rebuke/Correction
- Wisdom
- Discipline

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Truth
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If a teaching makes me feel good, it must be from God"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If a teaching makes me feel good, it must be from God." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does Paul say about teachers who suit our desires?
- ☐ Does God's Word ever correct me?
- ☐ Is this teaching true to all of Scripture?
- ☐ Have I needed a hard truth before?
- ☐ Am I avoiding this because it's wrong or uncomfortable?
- ☐ Can truth be loving and still hard to hear?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I test teaching by Scripture, not by feelings.
- ☐ God's Word comforts me and corrects me.
- ☐ Hard truths can be loving truths.
- ☐ God's Word is living and active.
- ☐ I want truth, not just comfort.
- ☐ The wounds of a friend are faithful.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **2 Timothy 4:3–4**
  "For the time will come when men will not tolerate sound doctrine, but with itching ears they will gather around themselves teachers to suit their own desires. So they will turn their ears away from the truth and turn aside to myths."
- [ ] **Hebrews 4:12**
  "For the word of God is living and active. Sharper than any double-edged sword, it pierces even to dividing soul and spirit, joints and marrow. It judges the thoughts and intentions of the heart."
- [ ] **2 Timothy 3:16–17**
  "All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for instruction, for conviction, for correction, and for training in righteousness, so that the man of God may be complete, fully equipped for every good work."
- [ ] **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- [ ] **Proverbs 27:6**
  "The wounds of a friend are faithful, but the kisses of an enemy are deceitful."

A verse I found myself: _____

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Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Sermon check:** After each sermon, video, or book, write: What did it say? How did it feel? Is it true to Scripture?
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, 2 Timothy 3:16–17 becomes: "All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for instruction, for conviction, for correction, and for training in righteousness, so that **Sarah** may be complete, fully equipped for every good work."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Rebuke/Correction" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Pick a teacher you enjoy and check one message** against Scripture, writing down any verses that confirm or challenge it.
- ☐ **Read a passage of Scripture that challenges you,** such as Matthew 5:21–48, and write one area where God is correcting you.
- ☐ **Ask a trusted Christian friend for honest feedback** on one area of your life, and thank them for it.
- ☐ **Read Matthew 4:1–11 and notice** that even the devil quoted Scripture to sound right.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If a teaching makes me feel good, it must be from God": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One teaching I tested
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If a teaching makes me feel good, it must be from God.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for the comfort of Your Word and for the correction it brings. Help me reject the lie that a teaching must be from You if it makes me feel good. Give me a love for Your truth, even when it is hard, and wisdom to test everything by Your Word. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.